

Moses Yang

Sweeping

Every April, he visits his mother.
He's home, but still far from home.

Whispers "You missed me, ma?" and
catches a glistening glare, for his mother had
sat by her phone, brown eyes glazed over,
waiting for a call from her only son.

The light catches her eyes cruelly and
his heart skips a beat, failing to strike
when their eyes meet. On his knees,
holding his tears tight to his chest,
he begs her for forgiveness.

He hopes and prays it's enough
 it's not
and offers to sweep her
house so she can rest.

He sees her sweeping too,
swiping the dusty sweat off her
furrowed brows in the summer
heat; her wrinkles trace rugged paths
through her face when she smiles,
cheeks tight as if to hint at the
weariness she carries in her bones.

He hears her humming to the tune
of her favorite melodies as she buzzes
around like a worker bee with places to be
and flowers to see in the spring.
He can hear her feet shuffling,
locked in rhythm with the
groaning of the stairs and the
gossip of the broom as she sweeps.

He sweeps now.
 sweep
 sweep
 sweep.

He makes her bed, and
kisses her on the forehead,
wiping her overgrown hair
away from her rough, cutting skin.
Her bed is clean now, but she
refuses to lift the covers and
drape his body with a hug.

The stone is cool to touch
 blistering
his fingers as he rubs his
thumb gingerly across the stiff patterns
that can only capture but a summary
of her vivacious and joyous life.

He weeps now.
 weep
 weep
 weep.